SharePoint Hybrid Navigation 202X

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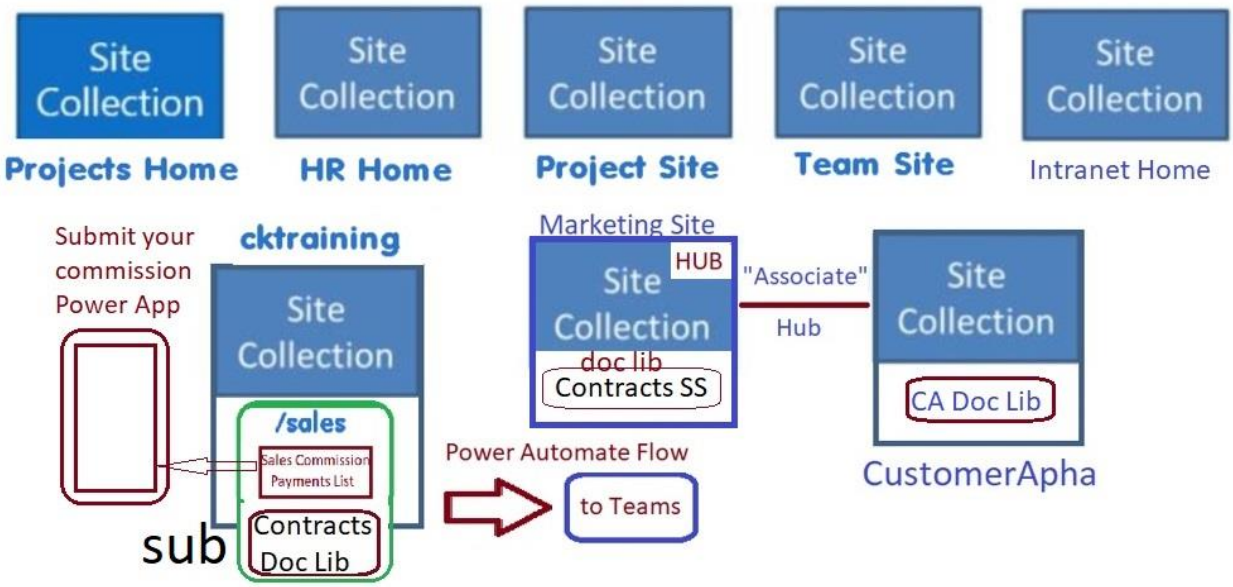
You're basically facing **the classic modern SharePoint navigation paradox**:

"We have hubs. We have site collections. We have subsites. We have users who need to jump around. Why is it STILL so hard to do simple navigation?"

Add SharePoint Wide Navigation Between Disconnected Site Collections & Sub Sites not in HUB

Copilot Q what is the quick, least maintenance needed way to go up from sub to parent - cross to non hub associated site collection to site/hub associated combo. Why is basic in site collection navigation so difficult to manage?



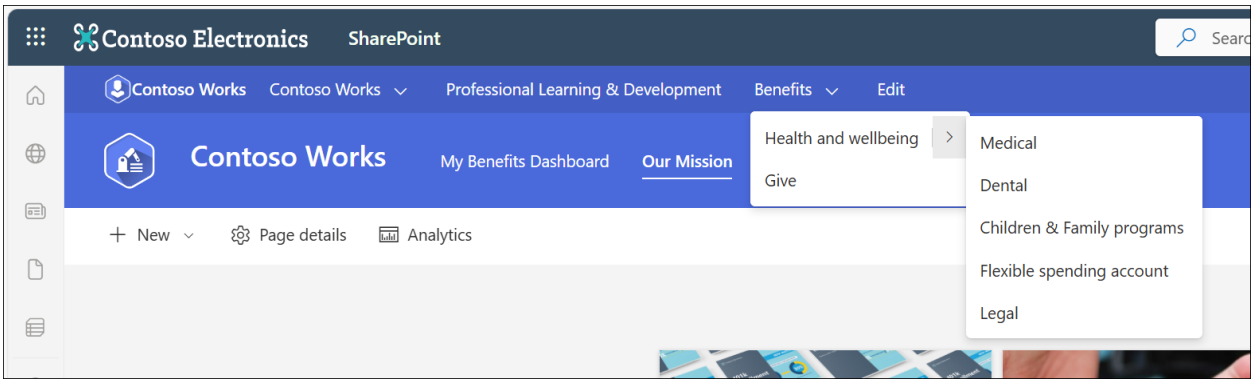
Your diagram is great — it shows exactly where the problem comes from:
Microsoft designed modern navigation ONLY for flat, hub-based architectures…
…but millions of organizations still have subsites and cross-site dependencies.

Below is the clearest breakdown of why navigation hybrids are painful *and* the easiest low-maintenance solutions.

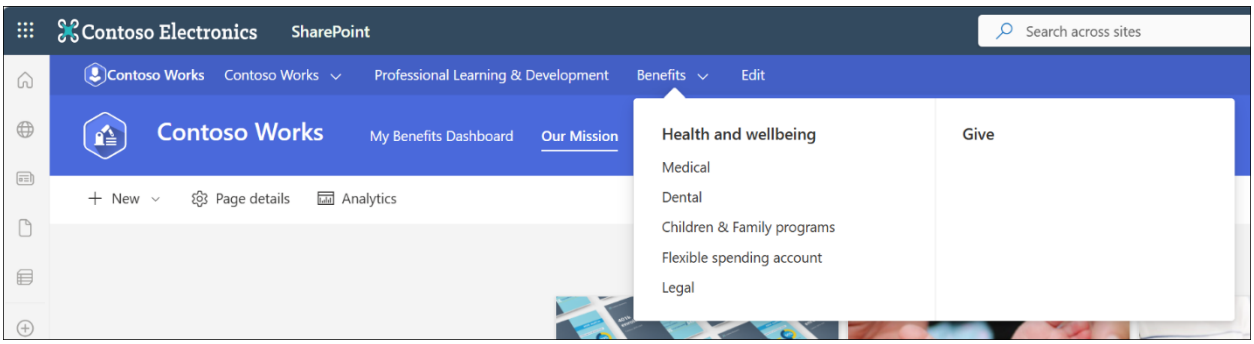
Navigation menus in SharePoint

There are two types of (newer) navigation menu styles for SharePoint sites - cascading and mega menu. Team sites and communication sites support both mega menus and cascading menus. Hubs, whether they are team sites or communication sites, add an additional mega menu to the site.

Cascading menu



Mega menu



✅ Part 1 — Why basic site collection navigation is so difficult to manage

Because **modern SharePoint navigation is intentionally limited to one of three scopes**, and none of them handle subsites + multiple site collections well.

1️⃣ Hubs → Only solve "horizontal" navigation

A hub solves these scenarios:

- Site collection A to site collection B
- Shared top navigation
- Shared theme
- Shared search
- Shared rollups

But **hubs do NOT apply downward to subsites**, which are considered "legacy."

So in your diagram, the Marketing Site (hub) can tie to CustomerAlpha, but the /sales subsite is orphaned from hub features.

2️⃣ Local site collection navigation is isolated

Inside a site collection:

- You can build local top navigation (Megamenu / Cascading)
- You can build local left navigation
- You can add links manually

But:

❌ It doesn't "see" other site collections
❌ It doesn't auto-update
❌ It doesn't inherit the hub nav
❌ It requires manual duplication

This is why you feel the pain.

3️⃣ People still have subsites, and subsites don't participate in modern nav

Subsites:

- Never inherit hub nav
- Never appear in hub rollups
- Can't be associated to hubs
- Have their own separate navigation store

They are **nav dead-ends** unless you manually hack in links.

This is exactly what your /sales subsite is suffering from.

✅ Part 2 — The Quickest, Lowest-Maintenance Navigation Hybrid Pattern

There **is** a pattern organizations use when they are in a hybrid world (some hubs, some standalone site collections, some subsites).

This is the architecture that creates the least admin overhead:

☆☆ Solution Pattern: Global Hub → Local Megamenus → Local "Back to Parent" links

You combine **three navigation layers**, each doing what it's best at:

Layer 1 — Global navigation via ONE hub

Use the *Marketing* site (in your image) as:

✓ The global jumping-off point
✓ A universal "You are here" anchor
✓ A cross-site navigation system

Task: **For sites NOT associated to the hub, you can still add manual links to them in the hub menu.

Purpose: Give users a consistent, always-available way to leave any site and jump anywhere else.

Layer 2 — Site collection–level Megamenu

Inside each site collection:

✓ Build a simple megamenu (3–7 items max)
✓ Include "Home," "Libraries," "Processes," "Resources," etc.

The key rule:

👉 **Do NOT duplicate global navigation locally.**
Only include pages that belong to that site collection.

This keeps maintenance low.

Layer 3 — "Back to Parent" link(s)

For sites not connected by a hub (subsites especially):

Use a simple, consistent convention:

Top-left link or breadcrumb replacement:

⬅ Back to [Parent Site / Home]

Examples:

- From /sales → back to **cktraining home**
- From CustomerAlpha → back to **Marketing Hub**
- From Projects → back to **Projects Home**

This is the only reliable, low-maintenance way for subsites to navigate "up."

Add it using:

- The **local site navigation** (top nav)
- Or a **banner** at the top of key pages
- Or a **custom SPFx navigation extension** (advanced)

🧭 **Why is this the least maintenance approach?**

Because each layer updates independently without forcing duplication:

Layer	Updates Required	Cost
Hub nav	1 location	**Lowest**
Local megamenu	Per site collection	Moderate
Back-to-parent link	Rarely changes	Lowest

You avoid:

- Duplicating global nav inside local nav
- Maintaining links in 20 places
- Rebuilding navigation every time a site is associated/disassociated from a hub

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🛑 What NOT to do

These patterns **explode admin cost**:

❌ Trying to force subsites into hub nav
❌ Duplicating the entire hub nav on every site collection
❌ Using 100+ manual quick links as a "navigation replacement"
❌ Dynamically generating nav via JSON every time a site changes
❌ Maintaining 12 hubs instead of 1–3 max

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🧩 Bonus: Your architecture's tricky point

In your diagram:

- The Marketing site is a hub
- The /sales subsite is NOT a hub member
- CustomerAlpha *is* a hub member

This creates:

🔷 **Sibling navigation = easy** (Marketing → CustomerAlpha)
🔷 **Parent → Subsite = broken** (Marketing Hub → /sales)
🔷 **Subsite → Hub = manual**
🔷 **Subsite → Sibling = impossible without manual links**

This is exactly why it feels harder than it should.

🚀 Recommended navigation design for YOUR diagram

Here is the best minimal-effort layout based on your scenario:

1. Hub navigation (Marketing Hub)

Includes:

- Marketing Home
- CustomerAlpha
- Projects Home
- HR Home
- Team Site
- Intranet

(NOTE: even non-hub sites can be linked in hub nav)

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2. Local nav for cktraining (the site hosting /sales)

Keep it simple:

- Home
- /sales
- Contracts Library
- Power App link

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3. Local nav for /sales subsite

Add:

- **⬅ Back to cktraining**
- Home
- Contracts Library
- Commissions List

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4. Local nav for CustomerAlpha

Add:

- **⬅ Back to Marketing Hub**
- CustomerAlpha Home
- CA Document Library

This creates a predictable flow:

- **Global → Collections** (hub)
- **Collections → Local content** (megamenu)
- **Local → Parent** (simple back link)

Minimal. Predictable. Maintainable.

🧭 SharePoint Online Navigation Architecture Blueprint

Designed for hybrid hubs + standalone site collections + subsites

Maximizes ease-of-use, minimizes maintenance

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1. Navigation Philosophy for Your Environment

Your environment contains:

- Multiple *standalone* modern site collections
- A *hub site* (Marketing)
- *Subsites* (example: /sales)
- Cross-site processes (Power Automate → Teams)
- Business-specific libraries (Contracts, CustomerAlpha documents)

These generate navigation needs that Microsoft's default model does *not* handle alone.

This blueprint solves the navigation problems in three layers:

🔷 Layer 1: Global Navigation (Hub Level — Marketing Hub)

Purpose: A single, universal "jump anywhere" bar available across all hub-associated sites.

Even sites NOT associated to the hub should still be manually linked here.

Global Hub Menu Structure

Global Navigation (Hub - Marketing Site)

- Home (Marketing)
- Projects Home
- HR Home
- Project Site
- Team Site
- Intranet Home
- CustomerAlpha Home
- cktraining Home

Notes

✓ You only maintain this navigation **in one place** (the hub)
✓ This allows navigation **between any major site collections**
✓ Even standalone sites appear here via manual links

Why this works

Users always have one "escape hatch" to get anywhere important.

🔷 **Layer 2: Local Navigation (Each Individual Site Collection)**

Purpose: Give users context about *this* site collection — not everything else.

Rule:

Only show what lives inside this site collection. Do not copy the hub menu.

Example — *cktraining* Site Collection

cktraining Navigation (local)

- Home
- Sales Subsite (/sales)
- Contracts Document Library
- Submit Your Commission (Power App)

- Resources

Example — *CustomerAlpha* Site Collection

CustomerAlpha Navigation (local)

- Home
- CA Document Library
- Processes
- Resources

Why this works

Users understand "this is everything *in this site collection*," not the entire company.

🔷 Layer 3: Subsite Navigation (Legacy Subsites)

Subsites cannot participate in hub navigation.

So we use the simplest and lowest-maintenance pattern:

Every subsite gets a single, consistent top-level link:

⬅ Back to [Parent Site Name]

Placed in:

- The local top navigation
- OR homepage text banner
- OR page header link

Example — *Sales* Subsite (/sales)

Sales Subsite Navigation

- ⬅ Back to cktraining
- Home
- Contracts Document Library
- Sales Commission Payments List

Why this works

Subsites feel connected without needing hub features (which they can't have anyway).

🧩 How Users Move Through Your Environment

Putting it all together:

From any hub-associated site → anywhere

Use the hub global navigation
(super low maintenance)

Within a site collection

Use the local megamenu
(no duplication, very clean)

From subsite → parent

Use the "Back to [Parent]" link
(works every time, lowest cost)

🔷 OPTIONAL (Recommended If You Want True Breadcrumbs)

If you want subsites to have **real breadcrumbs**, not just a back link:

- Use an SPFx *Breadcrumb Extension*
- Or a JSON navigation override
- Or a custom header placeholder

This adds only **one deploy/update location** → minimal maintenance.

If you'd like, I can generate this SPFx breadcrumb extension for you automatically.

🏗️ Final Deliverable: Your Full Navigation Blueprint Diagram

Here it is in text form — I can also render a graphical diagram if you want:

Marketing Hub (Global Nav)

│

├── Projects Home

├── HR Home

```
├── Project Site
├── Team Site
├── Intranet Home
├── CustomerAlpha Home
└── cktraining Home
  |
  ├── Contracts Library
  ├── Power App: Submit Your Commission
  └── Sales Subsite (/sales)
    |
    ├── ⬅ Back to cktraining
    ├── Contracts Document Library
    └── Sales Commission Payments List
```

```
CustomerAlpha (Hub Member)
|
├── CA Document Library
└── Processes / Resources modules
```

Advanced Navigation

Steps to Use an SPFx Breadcrumb Extension

1. **Environment Setup:** Ensure you have an SPFx development environment set up (Node.js, Gulp, Yeoman).
2. **Create Project:** Run the Yeoman SharePoint Generator (yo @microsoft/sharepoint) and choose Extension -> Application Customizer.
3. **Develop Component:** Use the Top placeholder to render the breadcrumb using React, querying the SharePoint REST API or PnP JS to retrieve navigation nodes.
4. **Test the Extension:** Use the serve.json file in the config folder to test the extension on a live SharePoint site using debug queries.
5. **Package and Deploy:** Build the project (gulp bundle --ship), package it (gulp package-solution --ship), and deploy the .sppkg file to the SharePoint App Catalog.

6. **Install/Activate:** Install the app on the site, and if not using tenant-wide deployment, activate the feature.

Key Considerations

- **Placeholders:** The Application Customizer provides Top and Bottom placeholders for placing the breadcrumb.
- **Best Practices:** Avoid direct DOM manipulation; use SPFx standard placeholders to prevent breaking during updates.
- **PnP Samples:** The PnP SPFx Breadcrumb sample is a robust starting point.

Create a mega menu in SharePoint Online (SPO)

Mega menus enable site navigation to be displayed at-a-glance on communication pages and hub sites. For Local (site) navigation, you must be a site owner and use a communication site or a hub-connected team site. It works best with three levels of hierarchy (Label > Sub-link > Sub-link).

Create a mega menu on communication sites and hub sites - Microsoft Support

Steps to Create a Local Mega Menu:

1. **Enable Navigation Editing:** Go to your site, click **Edit** at the bottom of the left-hand or top navigation menu.
2. **Create Hierarchy:**

1. Click **+** to add a new link or label.
2. To make a link a sub-item, click the ellipses (...) next to the link name and select **Make sub link**.
3. Create up to 3 levels: Header (Level 1) > Link (Level 2) > Sub-link (Level 3).

3. **Configure Mega Menu View:**

1. Go to **Settings** (gear icon) > **Change the look**.
2. Select **Navigation**.
3. Under **Orientation**, choose **Horizontal**.
4. Under **Menu style**, select **Mega menu**.
5. Click **Save**.

Key Tips:

- **Best Use:** Use all three levels of navigation for the best appearance.
- **Limitations:** Mega menus are not supported on classic publishing sites.
- **Labels:** Use Labels (non-clickable text) to organize groups of links.

How to customize the navigation of a communication site by adding a link/label to the top menu

- Go to the SharePoint Communication Site in which you wish to do the customization.
- From the top menu, click on **Edit** placed to the right.
- Move your mouse pointer to the location in the menu where you wish to add a link.
- Click **+**, and the **Add a link** dialog box will appear.
- You can pick from two options: **URL** or **Header**.
- To add a link to the menu, you just need to enter the web page address and give a display name.

- You can also choose **Header** option if you wish to add a label without a hyperlink.
- Go to the page to which you wish to add a link from the menu and copy the URL from the address bar.
- Paste the URL in the **Address bar** and enter the **Display name** that you desire.
- Click **OK** to confirm.
- To save the changes, you can click **Save**.
- You can click on **Cancel** if you want to discard all changes made.
- You could also change the navigation layout and choose either Cascade or Mega Menu.
- To make that change, go to **Change the look** option, and choose **Navigation**.

To perform these actions to customize the navigation you need to have at least the manage lists permission.

Steps to add or edit links/labels in a communication site footer

Before going to the steps to add or edit links/labels in a communication site footer, we would like to enlighten you about some basic facts. The site footer feature is only available on Communication Site Site Pages. You will not find it in Library pages, List Pages, or other pages on your communication site.

- Click on the **Edit** option placed on the right side of your footer.
- You need to have the footer control turned on to find this option.
- Go to the buttons on the left navigation pane and click **+** just above the buttons.
- In the **Add a link** dialog box that appears, enter the desired URL and display name.
- Click **Ok**.
- To edit existing links on the site footer, click the **Edit** option and click on the ellipses that show up near to the link you want to customize.
- From the **Edit**, **Move Up**/**Move Down**, and **Remove** options, choose the right options, and make necessary changes.
- Click on **Save** after making all desired changes.

How to add a link to the navigation bar of a hub site

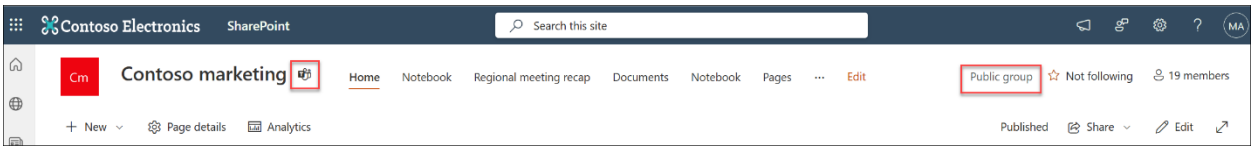
Look for the **Edit** option next to the Hub Site navigation bar. If you do not see that option, it means you do not have permission to make changes to the navigation. At least manage lists permissions are required to perform these steps. The changes you are making to the hub site navigation bar will take up to 2 hours to show up in the associated sites.

- Look for the **Edit** option placed on the right side of the hub site Navigation Bar.

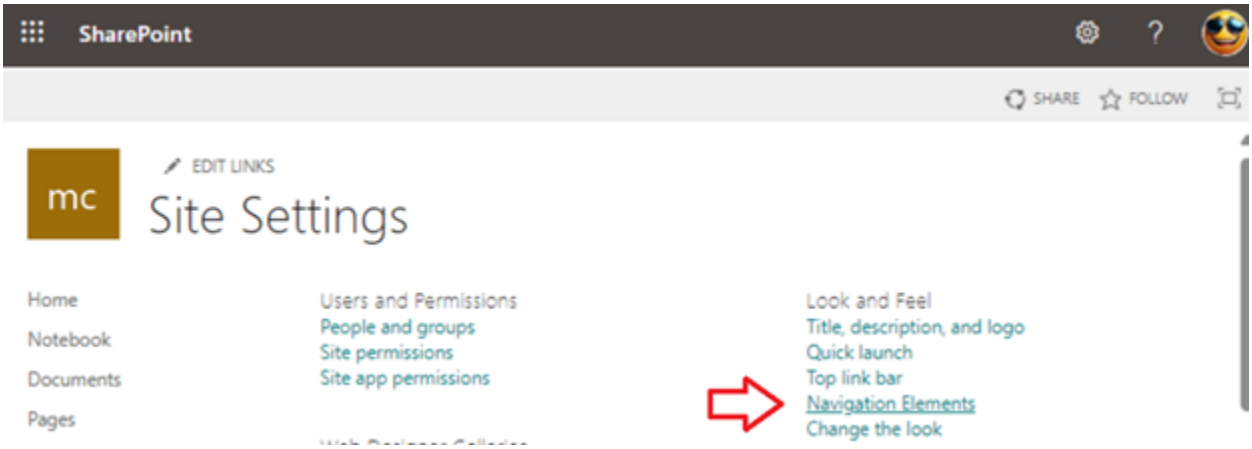
- Click on **Edit** and move your mouse pointer towards the area in the menu where you wish to add a link.
- Click on the **+** icon and the down arrow.
- From the **Add a link** dialog box that appears, you need to fill the **Address** box and **Display name** box.
- To find the correct URL of the web page you wish to add to the navigation bar, go to the page and copy the URL from the address bar.
- Past the URL in the box allotted in the Add a link box.
- Enter an appropriate display name for the box and click Ok.
- The text you are entering in the display name box will be the text that shows up on the menu.
- Click **Save** to complete the process.

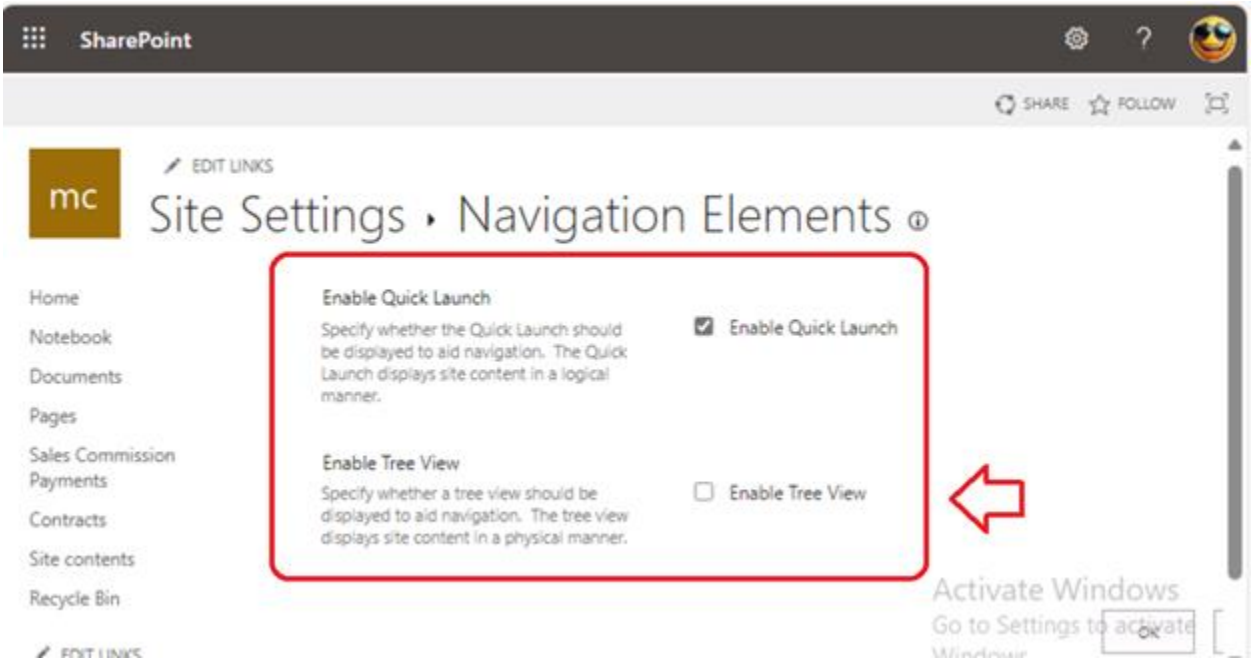
How to identify a team site

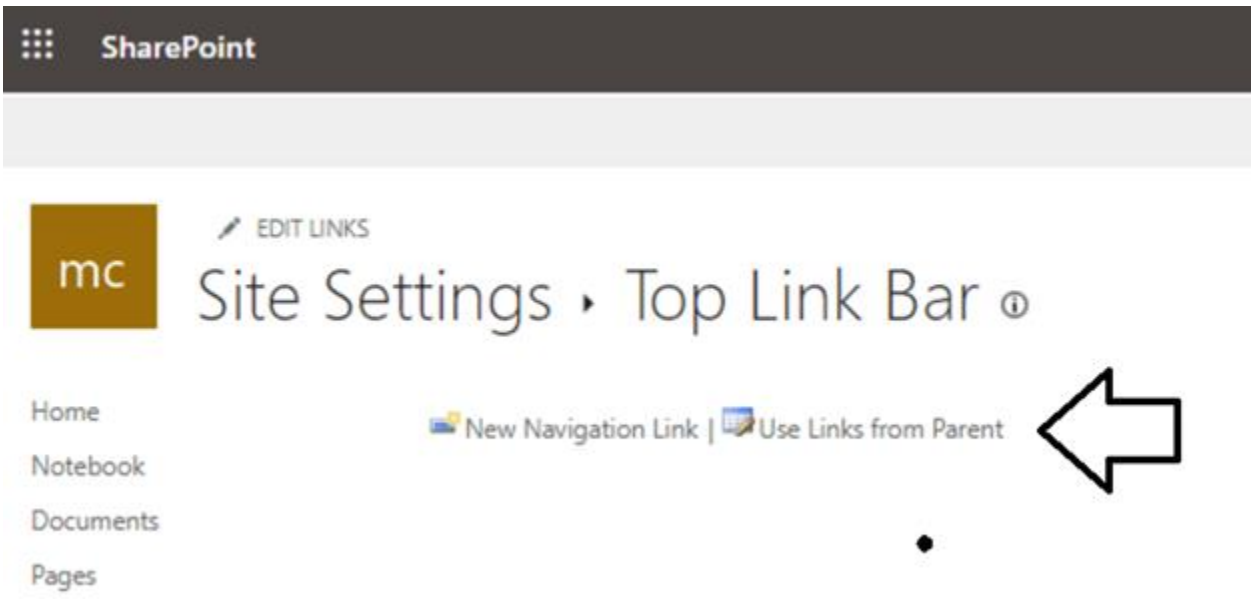
Both team sites and communication sites can have vertical or horizontal navigation bars. However, team sites display a Microsoft Teams channel icon next to the site's title. They also indicate if the site is public or private on the right side of the site header.



Navigation Settings Screenshots



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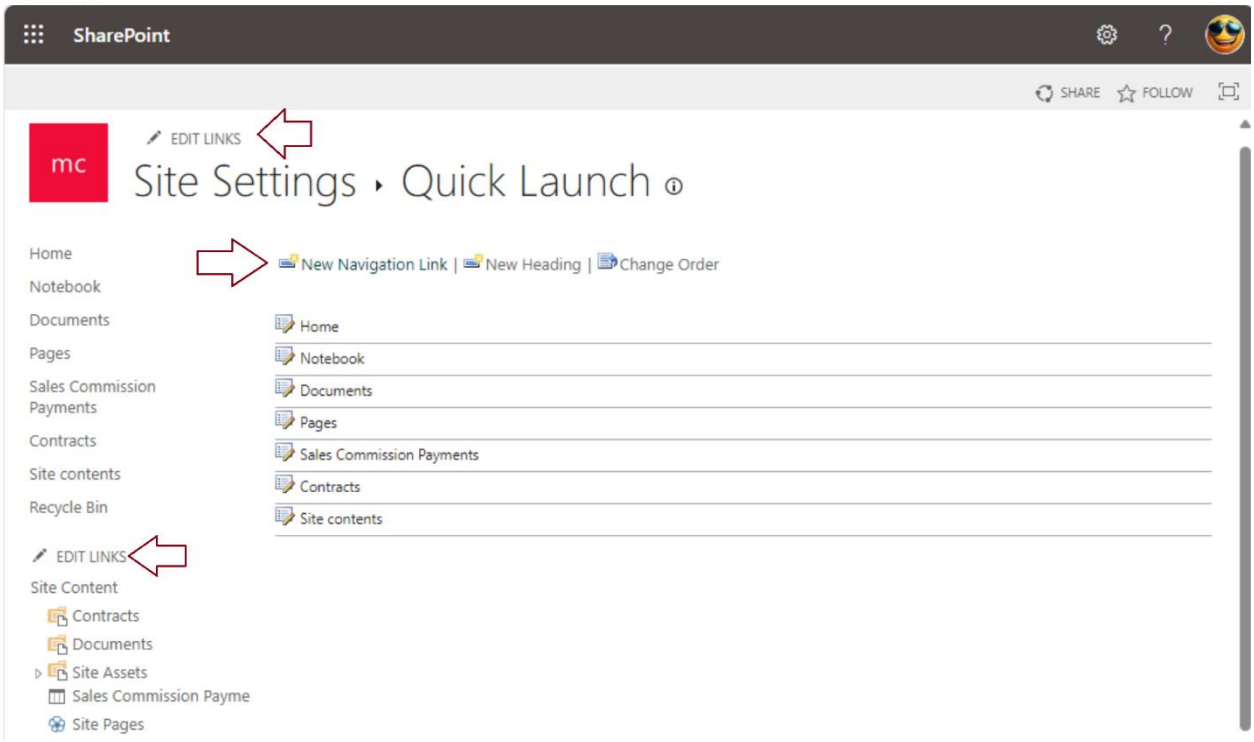
EDIT LINKS
Site Settings › Top Link Bar
Home
Notebook
Documents
Pages
New Navigation Link | Use Links from Parent


SharePoint
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Site Settings › Quick Launch
Home
Notebook
Documents
Pages
Sales Commission Payments
Contracts
Site contents
Recycle Bin
EDIT LINKS
Site Content
Contracts
Documents
Site Assets
Sales Commission Payme
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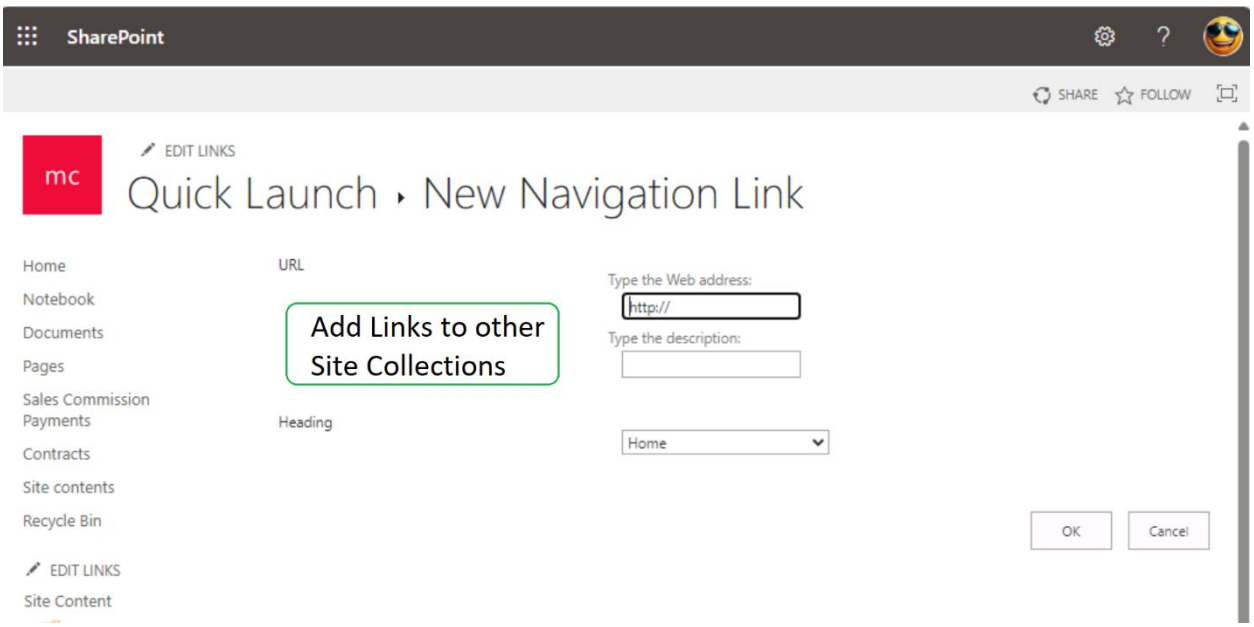
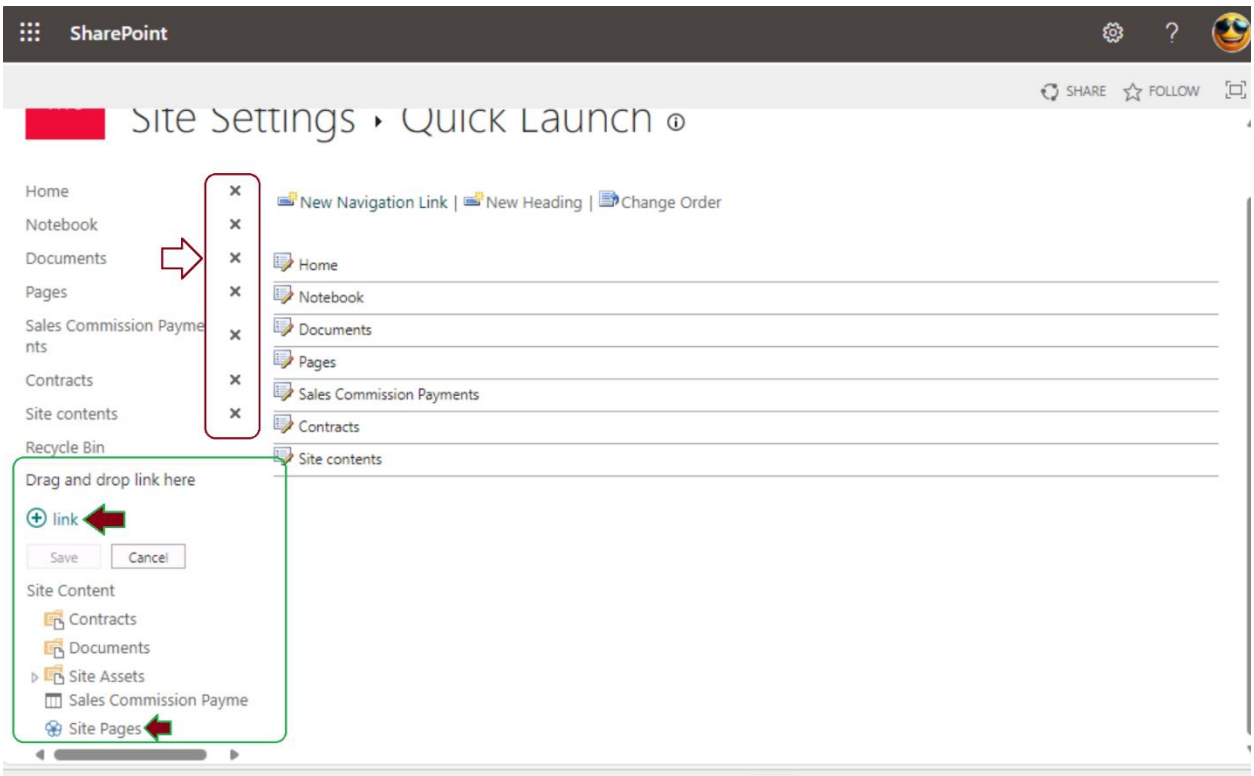
New Navigation Link | New Heading | Change Order
Home
Notebook
Documents
Pages
Sales Commission Payments
Contracts
Site contents





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9. The Viva Connections dashboard provides fast and easy access to information and job-related tasks. Content on the dashboard can be customized and then targeted to users in specific roles, markets, and job functions. It consists of cards that engage viewers with existing Microsoft Teams apps, Viva apps and services, partner apps, custom solutions using the SharePoint Framework (SPFx) framework, internal links, and external links.
10. What is a SharePoint team site? - Microsoft Support
11. To add links to your page rather than the vertical menu or horizontal menu, see Add a link to a page
12. How to Customize the Navigation of a SharePoint Communication Site and Hub Site